

» DURAND CUP



Historic haul: East Bengal powered past Mohun Bagan Super Giant 4-1 in Kolkata to lift its 17th Durand Cup, drawing level with its arch-rival as the tournament's joint-most successful side. PICS: DURAND CUP MEDIA

The past has a pulse



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As East Bengal ended a **22-year wait** for the Durand Cup, Asian football's oldest tournament offered fresh proof that tradition, rivalry and relevance can still thrive together.

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The celebrations began long before the final whistle.

East Bengal fans, starved of a major Durand Cup triumph for 22 years, turned the stands into a carnival as their beloved team produced a befitting performance, sweeping aside arch-rival Mohun Bagan Super Giant 4-1 to lift the trophy.

Flares lit up the galleries. Thousands of phone flashlights shimmered across the stadium. A few firecrackers made their way into the celebrations, while anything that could express the supporters' unbounded joy was pressed into service.

East Bengal's last Durand Cup triumph had also come against Bagan, when it won the 2004 final 2-1 at New Delhi's Ambedkar Stadium, the tournament's original home.

Since then, however, changing preferences had taken their toll. Legacy competitions such as the Durand Cup gradually faded as leading Indian teams focused increasingly on the top league, Indian Super League (ISL), and stopped participating regularly in invitational tournaments.

That began to change in 2019, when the organisers, the Indian Armed Forces, which has conducted the tournament since its inception in